

Chapter 161 Extra Chapter Three

Chu Qingqiu didn't look at her at all, so she could only cast a reassuring glance at Su Mo, then turned around and briskly opened and closed the door.

Leaning against the door and window, facing the autumn night beyond the railing, she buried her face in the blanket and let out a long breath.

She didn't leave immediately, still listening to the sounds from inside the room. She thought that if Chu Qingqiu and Su Mo couldn't get along, she would find another solution. But the room was quite peaceful, seemingly harmonious.

Su Mo slowly turned to face Chu Qingqiu. Chu Qingqiu didn't look at her much, only stiffly making a few hand gestures: "You sleep on the bed."

Then she walked to the window, turned over and half-reclined on the beauty couch¹, closing her eyes to rest.

Su Mo tiptoed onto the bed, and soon, light breathing sounds began to rise steadily. Ning Fuyi felt relieved and silently left.

Ning Fuyi stayed awake all night. Finally, at dawn when the wind rose, she waited for Jiuying and Jiang Li, both looking exhausted. The two rushed into the room without a word—one fanning herself while looking for water to drink, the other throwing a huge astrolabe² onto Ning Fuyi before sitting down with a flourish of her skirt.

"This is..." Ning Fuyi, who nearly got hit in the head by the bronze astrolabe, sat up on her knees and picked it up.

"Don't mention it. We started by asking Sect Master Tang, but got no useful information. Later we went to Penglai to find Yun Ke. She's the Left Envoy of Penglai and has always been skilled in astrology." Jiuying naturally crossed her legs on Ning Fuyi's bed. "According to her, the celestial phenomena have indeed been unstable recently. Five stars have shifted simultaneously, which could very likely cause local disruption of the cosmic order."

"Disruption of the cosmic order?" Ning Fuyi was startled, suddenly thinking of the reincarnation array.

"Don't panic. Yun Ke also said this is a normal effect of celestial changes. As long as the impact isn't too great, it's acceptable. Once the five stars return to their positions, the disruption will naturally disappear." Jiang Li, who had drunk several gulps of tea, wiped her mouth.

"You mean the shifting of the five stars happened to bring Su Mo to the present world." Ning Fuyi felt like she was hearing a fairy tale, involuntarily tugging at her hair.

"There's no other solution for now. We can only wait quietly for the chaotic phenomena to end." Jiang Li said.

Ning Fuyi's jaw dropped slightly, and she didn't speak for a long while. Finally, she pushed both the astrolabe and Jiuying aside and got out of bed.

Jiuying hugged the blanket and lay down comfortably, turning to her side: "So what are you planning to do now? Can Su Mo and the Divine Venerable accept each other?"

"What do you mean 'each other'? Su Mo is the Divine Venerable." Jiang Li retorted.

"But there are indeed two Divine Venerables now. Even if one is the complete Divine Venerable and one is the mortal Divine Venerable, fundamentally, there are now two people." Jiuying refused to back down.

Ning Fuyi felt dizzy from their back-and-forth arguing and could only cover her ears.

Actually, she herself was quite confused. The simultaneous appearance of Chu Qingqiu and Su Mo was something that should never have been possible, let alone knowing how to handle it.

"There's movement next door. They should be awake." Jiuying wiggled her feet and grinned mischievously, as if fearing the world wasn't chaotic enough. "How do you plan to wait for the five stars to return to position? You can't just leave them together like this."

"What else can we do, play mahjong?" Ning Fuyi pulled out several strands of black hair, feeling powerless.

"Su Mo seems to have stayed in that mountain village her whole life. Now that there's an opportunity, why not take her around Dianxing Town to have some fun?" Jiang Li spoke more reasonably and offered a suggestion.

"That's not a bad idea." Ning Fuyi nodded.

Half an hour later, the five of them appeared at the foot of the mountain, immersed in the bustling noise of the morning market.

Su Mo had indeed never seen such a prosperous town. Even the county seat hadn't been this lively and bustling. So she held onto Ning Fuyi's sleeve, her eyes chaotically reflecting the busy traffic. Even with her usually calm disposition, she felt curious.

Chu Qingqiu had originally disdained such things, but when Su Mo agreed quickly, thinking about the two of them going down the mountain alone to sightsee, Chu Qingqiu was somehow possessed and nodded in agreement.

Thus the current chaotic scene was born. Ning Fuyi stood in the middle with Su Mo on her left and Chu Qingqiu on her right, while those two troublemakers followed not far behind, laughing and chattering as they watched the show.

The people on the street could tell they were immortal elders from the mountain, so they all detoured around them when approaching. Thus, despite the bustling morning market, it wasn't too crowded. However, the vendors and peddlers on both sides became more enthusiastic, their calls echoing among the rows of eaves.

"Divine Venerable, there's a shop selling Sweet Snow Mountains³ up ahead, and also honey ice. Would you like to try a bowl?" Ning Fuyi turned her head and asked Chu Qingqiu with a smile.

Chu Qingqiu coldly glanced at those mortal foods and shook her head, showing no interest.

"Alright then." Ning Fuyi then looked down and gestured to Su Mo: "What about you?"

Su Mo's eyes curved as she raised her hands: "Sweet Snow Mountain, what is that?"

"It's a cooling food for mortals. They shave ice into sand—it's sweet and very refreshing." Ning Fuyi patiently explained. The foot of the mountain wasn't as cool as the mountaintop. Although it was late summer, the sun was still blazing, so hot it seemed like it could melt the rooftops.

"Good." Su Mo nodded while gazing intently at Ning Fuyi.

Seeing her agree, Ning Fuyi quickly ran toward a stall set up with a bamboo cart ahead. Her tall figure had flowing sleeves, and when she turned to face the vendor, her coal-black hair framed a sculptured, fair profile.

Seeing her carefully receiving the ceramic bowl and holding it in her arms, afraid it might melt in the sunlight, Chu Qingqiu's heart suddenly felt blocked, and even Su Mo's veil beside her became glaring.

Chu Qingqiu forced herself to lower her eyes. Cold sweat formed on her back as she was shocked to realize she was actually feeling jealous.

Chu Qingqiu, you're truly absurd. How could you develop such petty thoughts? She gripped the white bone at her waist tightly, not letting these emotions show even a bit.

In her daze, Ning Fuyi had already returned. She was handing the ceramic bowl and bamboo spoon to Su Mo, teaching her how to eat it.

Watching Su Mo stand there, treasuring each small bite of the ice water, Ning Fuyi's heart immediately softened. She wanted to reach out and touch her hair but quickly restrained herself.

Looking up again, Chu Qingqiu wasn't watching them but was staring intently at a peddler weaving grass insects nearby.

"Divine Venerable, that street has a Marriage Bridge⁴ and is also lively, but this street has morning markets on both sides. Which way would you like to go?" Ning Fuyi wanted to break the silence, so she asked carefully.

"Whatever." Chu Qingqiu still didn't look at her, only speaking flatly.

"Do you like this? I'll buy it for you." Ning Fuyi scratched the back of her head and walked toward the peddler.

"I don't like it." Chu Qingqiu looked at the lifelike grass insect and continued speaking.

Although she was usually cold, she wasn't this kind of dismissive cold. Now her eyes and brows carried a distant air, clearly displeased about something.

Ning Fuyi wasn't incapable of coaxing people, but in the current situation, although she knew what Chu Qingqiu was upset about, she couldn't think of any words to say. She could only stand there awkwardly.

But Chu Qingqiu suddenly spoke sullenly: "This venerable wants to eat again."

Ning Fuyi made a sound of confusion, then realized she was talking about the Sweet Snow Mountain, pressing her lips together as she almost laughed out loud.

This made Chu Qingqiu feel embarrassed, her thin lips tightly pressed, but in Ning Fuyi's eyes, it only made her adorably dizzy.

Ning Fuyi didn't expose her. She just turned around and bought another bowl, and while handing it to Chu Qingqiu, she flicked her forehead with her finger, then escaped before she could get angry.

"Hey, Yiyi, that shop ahead has excellent pastries. Buy some for Su Mo to try." Jiuying came forward and put her arm around Ning Fuyi's shoulder, eager to stir up trouble.

Su Mo kept smiling throughout. She wanted to treasure more of Ning Fuyi's kindness, so she didn't refuse anything Ning Fuyi offered. Thus, after Ning Fuyi led her around the morning market, Su Mo's belly became round.

To avoid Chu Qingqiu becoming unhappy again, Ning Fuyi bought a portion of everything for Chu Qingqiu as well, even when she said she didn't want it. By the end of their shopping, the food in Chu Qingqiu's arms could pile up like a mountain.

Chu Qingqiu finally lost patience and shoved all the items into Jiuying's hands, then lowered her head to dust off the oil stains on her clothes, trying to dispel those messy smells.

This journey exhausted Ning Fuyi's legs, having to take care of one person then go take care of the other, afraid of neglecting anyone. Jiuying and Jiang Li not only didn't help at all but watched with great interest from behind.

Chu Qingqiu basically didn't say a word, only occasionally uttering a few words. Su Mo was naturally silent too, but unable to resist the joy of being able to see Ning Fuyi for a few more days, she held onto her sleeve the entire way, never leaving her side.

Seeing the sun rise high and the heat under the eaves becoming even more oppressive, many vendors had retreated to the shade. The morning market's bustling traffic was replaced by midday quiet, and Ning Fuyi was finally freed, preparing to head home.

At this moment, beans drying on someone's rooftop weren't properly secured. The bricks holding down the coarse cloth slipped and were blown by wind, suddenly falling from the eaves like flowers scattered by heavenly maidens. Su Mo happened to be standing under the eaves, so bricks and beans came crashing down toward her head.

Several people noticed the accident simultaneously, but Ning Fuyi reacted fastest. The moment things started falling, a mass of black energy surged from her palm, acting like a rope to pull Su Mo into the air and bring her to safety.

The surrounding people scattered in fright. Su Mo was also startled, instinctively hugging Ning Fuyi's waist tightly and nestling in her arms, her brow furrowed.

"Yiyi..." she screamed softly, as if only Ning Fuyi's embrace was the safest place.

"It's okay, it's okay. Just some beans, don't be afraid." Ning Fuyi softened her voice to comfort her while gently patting her back and gathering the scattered bricks and beans into a pile.

The owner of the beans, an old man with a walking stick, heard the commotion and rushed out from inside. He was so anxious he dropped his cane. Seeing that no one was hurt, he finally breathed a sigh of relief: "Are you young ladies frightened? It's all this old man's fault—my old bones can't even dry beans properly..."

Jiang Li sensed the suddenly cold atmosphere and put away her spectator mentality, hurrying out to smooth things over. With a flower-like smile, she picked up the old man's cane: "It's fine, it's fine. Nobody got hit. Just dry your beans in the courtyard from now on."

As she spoke, she bent down to clean up the mess and chatted kindly with the old man. After Ning Fuyi comforted Su Mo and looked up again, in the blazing sunlight ahead, only Jiuying remained, shrugging helplessly at her.

Chu Qingqiu had left.

Author's Note: Divine Venerable: Then I'm leaving!

Footnotes:

¹ Beauty couch (美人榻) - An elegant reclining couch traditionally used by women in ancient China

² Astrolabe (占星盘) - An ancient astronomical instrument used for divination and studying celestial movements

³ Sweet Snow Mountains (酥山) - A traditional Chinese dessert made from shaved ice, similar to modern snow cones

⁴ Marriage Bridge (姻缘桥) - A traditional Chinese bridge associated with romantic destiny and matchmaking